

THE WAY

# Theological Research Method & Library of Witnesses

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*Evidence architecture for inquiry, source stewardship, and doctrine restraint*

Encounter -> Testimony -> Interpretation -> Teaching -> Doctrine

**Version 0.8 | September 19, 2026**

**UNDECIDED**

**Research draft - not a closed canon or creed**

**Core rule**

A source is admitted to the Library because it is a relevant witness, not because the Assembly has declared every statement in it inspired, infallible, or binding.

## Executive purpose

The Library of Witnesses is the research and source architecture through which the Assembly studies religious claims without confusing reverence, antiquity, sincerity, institutional adoption, or majority opinion with proof.

Its purpose is not to flatten traditions into one system. It preserves disagreement, provenance, genre, transmission history, community interpretation, and uncertainty so that the Way can learn from witnesses without claiming more than the evidence warrants.

## 1. Governing research commitments

Reality precedes the institution. Neither the founder, Board, Assembly, a sacred text, nor a majority vote makes a proposition true merely by declaring it.

Encounter is distinguished from testimony; testimony from interpretation; interpretation from teaching; and teaching from doctrine.

Historical questions, textual questions, phenomenological questions, metaphysical questions, theological questions, ethical questions, and institutional questions require different kinds of evidence. A strong historical conclusion does not automatically prove a metaphysical interpretation.

Religious traditions are allowed to speak in their own categories before comparative synthesis. Similar vocabulary does not establish identical meaning.

Dissent and negative evidence must be preserved. Research records should state what evidence would materially lower as well as raise confidence.

## 2. Evidence layers

| Code | Layer                          | Function                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|------|--------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| P1   | Primary / near-primary witness | Earliest available text, inscription, artifact, or testimony sufficiently close to the relevant period or event. Proximity raises evidentiary value but does not make the witness infallible. |
| P2   | Early community witness        | Early texts and practices showing how a community remembered, interpreted, or ritualized a claim.                                                                                             |
| P3   | Later traditional witness      | Later commentary, biography, creed, hagiography, legal tradition, or institutional interpretation. Strong for reception history; variable for reconstructing origins.                         |

| Code | Layer                                     | Function                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|------|-------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| H    | External historical / material evidence   | Independent literary sources, archaeology, epigraphy, manuscript evidence, social history, linguistics, and related disciplines.                                                                                  |
| PH   | Philosophical analysis                    | Conceptual coherence, arguments, counterarguments, explanatory scope, and alternative metaphysical models.                                                                                                        |
| EX   | Experiential / phenomenological testimony | Reported religious, mystical, contemplative, moral, or transformative experience. Evidence that an experience was reported or occurred as experience is not identical to proof of its theological interpretation. |
| PR   | Practice evidence                         | Observed effects, reproducibility where meaningful, ethical fruit, harms, and community outcomes. Practical benefit does not by itself prove a metaphysical explanation.                                          |

### 3. Claim taxonomy

| Claim class      | Question                                                              | Principal methods                                                                                        |
|------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Historical       | What probably happened in time and place?                             | Ancient-source criticism, archaeology, external attestation, contextual plausibility.                    |
| Textual          | What does a source say, and how was it transmitted?                   | Manuscripts, philology, redaction, genre, textual criticism.                                             |
| Phenomenological | What was experienced or reported?                                     | First-person testimony, comparative phenomenology, psychology; interpretation held separate.             |
| Metaphysical     | What ultimately exists?                                               | Philosophical argument, coherence, explanatory power; history alone cannot settle it.                    |
| Theological      | What does a tradition claim about God, revelation, salvation, etc.?   | Primary sacred sources, doctrinal history, internal reasoning; distinguish description from endorsement. |
| Ethical          | What ought persons or communities do?                                 | Moral reasoning, consequences, rights, virtue, duties, human flourishing, tradition.                     |
| Institutional    | What authority should the Assembly grant a belief, source, or person? | Governance, rights impact, evidence quality, mission fit, anti-coercion controls.                        |

## 4. Confidence states

| State                              | Meaning                                                                                                                                                               |
|------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Established                        | Strong evidence and broad responsible agreement for the defined claim; revision remains possible.                                                                     |
| Well-Supported                     | Substantial evidence favors the claim, but meaningful uncertainty or dispute remains.                                                                                 |
| Provisional                        | Plausible working conclusion useful for practice or further inquiry, explicitly subject to revision.                                                                  |
| Permitted Interpretation           | A coherent interpretation Companions may hold, but the Assembly does not teach it as the best-established conclusion.                                                 |
| Open Question                      | Available evidence does not justify an Assembly conclusion.                                                                                                           |
| Rejected as Harmful or Unsupported | Either evidentially untenable for the defined claim, or institutionally impermissible because the proposed use violates rights/safeguards. The reason must be stated. |

## 5. Evaluation protocol

Step 1 - Frame the claim narrowly enough to test. Separate compound claims into historical, textual, metaphysical, and ethical components.

Step 2 - Identify the earliest available witnesses, their genre, date range, language, provenance, and relationship to the events or claims described.

Step 3 - Map transmission: oral, manuscript, editorial, canonical, liturgical, interpretive, and institutional stages. Later tradition is evidence about later belief even when it is weak evidence for an earlier event.

Step 4 - Seek independent corroboration and disconfirming evidence. Agreement among sources that depend on one another is not independent attestation.

Step 5 - Compare major scholarly and traditional interpretations. Attribute contested judgments rather than laundering them into institutional fact.

Step 6 - Assess explanatory alternatives, including naturalistic, psychological, social, literary, and theological interpretations where relevant.

Step 7 - Assign confidence separately to each claim. Do not average different claim types into one verdict about a person or tradition.

Step 8 - Record practical implications and a rights-impact check. No research conclusion bypasses safeguarding, consent, financial controls, civil law, or participant rights.

Step 9 - Record what would change our mind, unresolved questions, and a review date.

## 6. Library of Witnesses architecture

The Library is open and versioned. Inclusion means 'relevant witness worthy of preserved study,' not 'canon,' 'infallible,' or 'endorsed in every claim.'

Every item receives a stable witness ID, source tradition, date range, original language where known, genre, provenance, transmission note, community status, principal claims, research status, and links to translations or editions.

A source can be spiritually formative while remaining historically difficult; historically valuable while theologically rejected; or authoritative within a source tradition without becoming authoritative for the Assembly.

## 7. Canon firewall

No item enters an Assembly canon merely by being included in the Library of Witnesses, cited frequently, read in worship, or favored by the founder.

Any future canonization proposal requires a separate constitutional process, including historical review, theological rationale, dissent record, rights-impact analysis, public comment, and supermajority safeguards. v0.8 recommends no Assembly canon at formation.

## 8. Research ethics and anti-coercion

No person must assent to a research conclusion as a condition of basic safety, access to ordinary worship, charitable assistance, family contact, housing, wages, or the right to leave.

Claims of prophecy, revelation, spiritual attainment, or founder insight receive no evidentiary shortcut. A claim concerning the claimant's own authority, compensation, discipline, sexual access, or exemption from controls receives heightened skepticism and independent review.

Children are taught how traditions understand their own claims and how evidence is evaluated; they are not required to profess certainty beyond their developmental capacity or conscience.

## 9. Output types

Research dossier - a full evidence map for a major question.

Witness note - provenance and interpretation record for one source.

Claim record - one proposition with evidence, objections, confidence, and revision criteria.

Teaching proposal - a research conclusion proposed for communal formation, clearly labeled by confidence.

Doctrine proposal - reserved for the rare case where a teaching needs formal status; doctrine requires the separate v0.6/v0.7 adoption process.

## 10. Stable research record

- Claim as framed
- Claim class(es)
- Witness IDs
- Evidence supporting
- Evidence against / limitations
- Competing interpretations
- Current confidence
- Rights/institutional implications

- What would change confidence
- Review date and reviewer

## 11. Foundational dossier queue

| ID     | Question                               | v0.8 status               |
|--------|----------------------------------------|---------------------------|
| TQ-001 | God / Ultimate Reality                 | Baseline dossier complete |
| TQ-002 | Revelation / Prophecy                  | Baseline dossier complete |
| TQ-003 | Jesus / Christology                    | Baseline dossier complete |
| TQ-004 | Muhammad / Qur'anic Revelation         | Baseline dossier complete |
| TQ-005 | Buddha / Awakening / Non-Self          | Baseline dossier complete |
| TQ-006 | Scripture / Canon / Authority          | Baseline dossier complete |
| TQ-007 | Human Condition / Soul / Consciousness | Baseline dossier complete |

## 12. Source notes

**S1 - Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, "Philosophy of Religion".** Alternative concepts of God/ultimate reality; religious and naturalistic worldviews. <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/philosophy-religion/>

**S2 - Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, "God and Other Ultimates".** Plural models of ultimacy: God, Brahman, Dao, emptiness, and others. <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/god-ultimates/>

**S3 - Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, "Divine Revelation".** Models of revelation and epistemic justification. <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/divine-revelation/>

**S4 - Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, "Religious Diversity (Pluralism)".** Exclusivist, inclusivist, pluralist responses; incompatible claims. <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/religious-pluralism/>

**S5 - Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, "The Problem of Evil".** Different concepts of God and evidential/logical problem of evil. <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/evil/>

**S6 - Sefaria, Deuteronomy 6:4-5 / Shema.** Jewish biblical witness to divine unity and love of God. <https://www.sefaria.org/Deuteronomy.6.4>

**S7 - Sefaria, Genesis 1:27.** Image-of-God anthropology. <https://www.sefaria.org/Genesis.1.27>

**S8 - Quran.com, Surah al-Ikhlās 112.** Qur'anic divine unity/incomparability. <https://quran.com/al-ikhlas>

**S9 - Quran.com, Qur'an 30:30.** Fitrah language. <https://quran.com/30/30>

**S10 - Quran.com, Qur'an 91:7-10.** Soul, moral discernment, purification/corruption. <https://quran.com/91/7-10>

**S11 - Quran.com, Qur'an 33:40.** Muhammad as messenger and seal of prophets in Qur'anic text. <https://quran.com/33/40>

**S12 - Oxford Academic, F. E. Peters, "Muhammad" (Oxford Bibliographies).** Qur'an as principal early biographical source; broad scholarly judgment about proclamation. <https://academic.oup.com/reference/62361/reference-article-abstract/554568841>

**S13 - Oxford Academic, Nathanael J. Andrade, Killing the Messiah (2025).** Current historical analysis of Jesus, Gospels, Pilate, and crucifixion. <https://academic.oup.com/book/59249>

**S14 - Oxford Academic, Graham Stanton, The Gospels and Jesus, "Assessing the Evidence".** Gospels as sources written decades later using oral traditions. <https://academic.oup.com/book/50340/chapter-abstract/422785887>

**S15 - Oxford Academic, Christopher Bryan, The Resurrection of the Messiah, Prologue.** Crucifixion under Pilate as exceptionally secure historical datum; early follower claims.

<https://academic.oup.com/book/5689/chapter-abstract/148771264>

**S16 - Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, "Buddha".** Historical Buddha, early teachings, non-self, karma/rebirth, liberation. <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/buddha/>

**S17 - SuttaCentral, SN 56.11.** Early Buddhist witness to four truths, middle way, eightfold path.

<https://suttacentral.net/sn56.11/en/bodhi>

**S18 - SuttaCentral, SN 22.59.** Early Buddhist witness to non-self analysis. <https://suttacentral.net/sn22.59/en/sujato>

**S19 - Cambridge University Press, R. S. Bucknell, Reconstructing Early Buddhism, "Scriptural Sources".** Multiple early Buddhist textual lineages and comparative reconstruction.

<https://www.cambridge.org/core/books/abs/reconstructing-early-buddhism/scriptural-sources/43CC4E66C9D03DCA5959F613D7B09CBD>

**S20 - Oxford Academic, Donald Senior, "Formation of the Canon and Creation of the New Testament".** Gradual NT canon formation and criteria. <https://academic.oup.com/book/41140/chapter-abstract/350492151>

**S21 - Oxford Academic, Timothy Lim, "Authoritative Scriptures and the Dead Sea Scrolls".** Qumran authority and graded authoritative literature. <https://academic.oup.com/edited-volume/34366/chapter-abstract/291495791>

**S22 - Oxford Academic, John D. Meade, "Formation of the Christian Canon" (2025).** Recent overview of Christian canon evidence and disputed books. <https://academic.oup.com/edited-volume/61539/chapter-abstract/537116629>

**S23 - Oxford Academic, James C. VanderKam, "Formation of the Jewish Canon" (2025).** Recent review of evidence for Jewish canon and authority. <https://academic.oup.com/edited-volume/61539/chapter-abstract/537115912>

**S24 - SGPC, "Basic Articles".** Official Sikh institutional summary of one God, equality, haumai, truthful living.

<https://sgpc.net/sikhism/basic-articles/>

**S25 - Bible Gateway, Mark 7:20-23.** Jesus tradition on inner moral defilement. <https://www.biblegateway.com/passage/?search=Mark%207%3A20-23>